



Successful organisational transformation requires more than selecting the right change strategy or following a structured implementation plan. This Executive Insight integrates three foundational perspectives on planned change—Chin and Benne's change strategies, Lewin's three-stage model, and the Worldview LOA Framework's three moments of change—to explain why identical change interventions often produce dramatically different outcomes. Sustainable acceleration depends not simply on what leaders do, or when they do it, but on how organisational members internalise, evaluate and enact change.

Three Ways of Understanding Planned Change

For more than half a century, planned organisational change has been guided by two enduring frameworks.

The first, developed by ***Chin and Benne****, explains* ***how*** *leaders attempt to influence change. They proposed three broad strategies.* ***Empirical-Rational*** *strategies assume people will embrace change when presented with convincing evidence and logical arguments.* ***Normative-Re-educative*** *strategies recognise that lasting change occurs by reshaping shared values, relationships and organisational*



*culture. **Power-Coercive** strategies rely on authority, compliance and formal control to achieve implementation.*

*The second framework, developed by **Kurt Lewin**, explains **where** organisations are within the change journey. Organisations first **unfreeze** existing assumptions and routines, then **change** through experimentation and adaptation, before **refreezing** new behaviours into stable patterns that support future performance. Together, these two models have shaped generations of organisational development practice and remain the foundation of most planned change interventions.*

Yet an important question remains unanswered.

If organisations apply the same change strategy, and move through the same stages of change, why do leaders facing identical circumstances often respond so differently?

The Missing Link: Three Moments of Change

The answer lies in recognising that organisational change is not only something that happens to organisations—it is something that happens within people.

*Drawing on the Worldview LOA Framework, this research identifies **three moments of change** that explain how organisational interventions become behavioural outcomes. These moments occur within every leader as they encounter, interpret and ultimately enact organisational change.*

*The **first moment** is **internalisation**.*

As executives encounter a new change strategy, they do not simply decide whether they support it. Instead, they evaluate whether the proposed change aligns with what they believe is legitimate, appropriate and worthwhile. This process produces three distinct patterns of response. Some suppress the change by delaying action or complying only symbolically. Others exploit the change to reinforce existing interests or authority. Others engage in genuine exchange, treating the strategy as an opportunity for shared learning and organisational improvement. Although these responses may appear similar on the surface, they represent fundamentally different interpretations of the same intervention.

*The **second moment** is **worldview activation**.*

Once leaders have interpreted the strategy, deeper evaluative structures become activated. They ask whether the change is morally legitimate, whether they feel genuinely obligated to support it, and whether they possess sufficient agency to influence the outcome. When these evaluations align, leaders experience commitment, confidence and purpose. When they conflict with deeply held beliefs or



identities, resistance, uncertainty and disengagement emerge. At this point, successful change depends less on communication or compliance than on activating meaningful commitment.

*The **third moment** is **enactment through position-practices**.*

Leaders begin translating their evaluations into action. They allocate resources, redesign decision-making forums, encourage experimentation, reshape conversations and reinforce new organisational norms. These everyday leadership practices determine whether change becomes embedded within the organisation or gradually loses momentum. Transformation succeeds when new meanings become visible through new patterns of leadership behaviour.

Connecting the Three Frameworks

Viewed together, these three perspectives provide a richer understanding of organisational transformation.

Chin and Benne explain how leaders attempt to influence change.

Lewin explains where those interventions occur within the planned change process.

The Three Moments explain why those same interventions produce different behavioural outcomes.

This integrated perspective moves beyond treating change as a sequence of activities. Instead, it recognises that organisational transformation depends on the interaction between external interventions and internal interpretation. Change strategies establish the conditions for transformation. The three stages provide the temporal structure. The three moments determine whether those interventions become meaningful, energising and behaviourally consequential.

Leading Change Through Meaning Rather Than Momentum

Many organisations attempt to accelerate transformation by increasing urgency, compressing timelines or strengthening governance. While these actions may increase organisational activity, they do not necessarily increase commitment.

Acceleration occurs when leaders internalise change through genuine exchange rather than suppression or exploitation. It occurs when worldviews are activated through legitimacy, obligation and agency rather than fear or compliance. It occurs when leaders consistently reinforce new ways of working through their everyday position-practices.

In other words, organisations move faster when people change sooner.

The implication for leaders is profound. Successful transformation is not achieved simply by selecting the right change strategy or progressing efficiently through Lewin's stages. Sustainable change



emerges when those interventions align with how people interpret the world around them. By understanding the three strategies, the three stages and the three moments of change together, leaders can create change processes that are not only faster, but also more participative, more resilient and more enduring.